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MATAYOSHI LINEAGE · OKDR FOUNDED 2002

Kobudo

古武道

The way of ancient weapons.

OKDR carries forward the Matayoshi kobudo lineage — bo, sai, tonfa, nunchaku, kama, eku, and other traditional Okinawan weapons.

Founded in 2002 by Gakiya Yoshiaki Sensei. Continued today under President Hanshi Neil Stolsmark.

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2002

OKDR FOUNDED

9th

DAN · HANSHI STOLSMARK

6+

CORE WEAPONS

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DOUSHI · COMRADES

—

A RICH HERITAGE CONTINUES

The Matayoshi lineage.

Our kobudo descends directly from Matayoshi Shinpo Sensei, one of the great preservers of Okinawan weapons tradition. The lineage continues unbroken through OKDR today.

MATAYOSHI KODOKAN ·
FOUNDER

Matayoshi Shinpo Sensei

又吉 真豊 · master of the Matayoshi lineage

One of the great masters of Okinawan kobudo in the 20th century, heir to the Matayoshi family tradition that spans generations. Led the Matayoshi Kodokan dojo in Okinawa and passed in September 1997, naming Gakiya Yoshiaki Sensei as his successor.

SUCCESSOR · FOUNDER OF
OKDR

Gakiya Yoshiaki Sensei

our teacher · former Kancho, Matayoshi Kodokan

Named successor to the Matayoshi lineage upon Shinpo Sensei's passing in 1997. After retiring as Kancho of the Matayoshi Kodokan dojo, founded the Okinawa Kobudo Doushi Rensei-Kai® in January 2002. Worked unselfishly for ten years developing OKDR, attracting practitioners from around the world. Forced to retire in 2011 due to unexpected illness.

HANSHI · 9TH DAN ·
PRESIDENT

Neil Stolsmark Sensei

honbu dojo · Waukesha, Wisconsin

Senior kobudo student of Gakiya Sensei. Appointed President of OKDR in 2011 upon Gakiya Sensei's retirement. Continues the tradition worldwide, leading the annual Warrior Gasshuku and certifying ranks. Photographed with Gakiya Sensei in Nago, Okinawa, 2013 — a relationship of teacher and successor that continues to guide the organization today.

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CURRICULUM

Traditional Okinawan weapons.

The core weapons of the Matayoshi lineage. Each carries its own kata, applications, and a history rooted in Okinawan agricultural and seafaring life.

棒

Bo

The six-foot staff. The foundational weapon of Okinawan kobudo — long reach, devastating strikes, foundational for all subsequent weapons study.

釵

Sai

The trident-shaped truncheon, typically carried in pairs. Used for trapping, striking, and countering bladed weapons.

トンファー

Tonfa

The side-handled baton, paired. Derived from a millstone handle, used for blocking, striking, and joint manipulation.

ヌンチャク

Nunchaku

Two short sticks connected by cord or chain. Originally a rice flail. Trains coordination, timing, and fluid striking.

鎌

Kama

The agricultural sickle, used in pairs. Cutting, hooking, and trapping techniques drawn from farm work and refined into combat application.

エーク

Eku

The boat oar. A weapon born from Okinawan seafaring culture — long reach, sweeping strikes, and distinctive sand-throwing applications.

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THE CREST

Meaning behind the mark.

The Hidari Mitsu-Domoe at the center symbolizes three souls circling clockwise — the crest of the Ryukyu royal families. The nine crowns around it express OKDR's hope: that Okinawan kobudo will expand and develop throughout the world through dedicated practice by our comrades.

左三つ巴 · Hidari Mitsu-Domoe

Three souls circling clockwise. The historic crest of the Ryukyu royal families of Okinawa.

九修錬行 · Kushu-Rengyō

Be skilled in martial arts through many years of training.

苦行究極 · Kugyō-Kyūkyoku

Master the true martial arts through unbearable practice.

Nine crowns express both phrases — "nine" is pronounced "ku" in Japanese, the same sound that begins each of the two principles.

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PHILOSOPHY

Doushi Rensei-Kai

The name OKDR is not arbitrary. It expresses what the organization is — and what its members are to each other.

同志

DOUSHI

People who share the same will. Comrades on the same path, bound by common purpose.

錬成

RENSEI

Train your body and soul. Forge yourself through disciplined, sustained practice.

The Okinawa Kobudo Doushi Rensei-Kai is an organization of people who pursue maturity of one's personality through learning Okinawa Kobudo. The weapons are the vehicle. The path is the practitioner.

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LEADERSHIP

Continuing Gakiya Sensei's work.

OKDR is led today by Hanshi Neil Stolsmark, appointed President in 2011. He continues to train under the traditions handed down from Matayoshi Shinpo Sensei through Gakiya Yoshiaki Sensei.

HANSHI · 9TH DAN · PRESIDENT

Neil Stolsmark

President, OKDR International

Senior kobudo student of Gakiya Yoshiaki Sensei. Appointed President of OKDR in 2011 upon Gakiya Sensei's retirement, and has led the worldwide organization since — growing membership across continents and continuing the annual Warrior Gasshuku tradition.

Also holds the rank of Kyoshii, 8th Dan in Shorin-Ryu Shorinkan karate as a first-generation American student of the late Hanshi Shugoro Nakazato.

KOBUDO RANK

Hanshi · 9th Dan

ROLE

President, OKDR

LINEAGE

Matayoshi · Gakiya

SINCE

President · 2011

FOUNDER · IN MEMORIAM

Gakiya Yoshiaki

Founder, OKDR · Successor to Matayoshi Shinpo

Founded the Okinawa Kobudo Doushi Rensei-Kai in January 2002 after retiring as Kancho of the Matayoshi Kodokan dojo. Named successor to Matayoshi Shinpo Sensei in 1997. Worked unselfishly for ten years developing OKDR before retiring in 2011 due to unexpected illness.

His teaching, vision, and the lineage he carried forward remain the foundation of everything OKDR does today.

ROLE

Founder, OKDR

FOUNDED OKDR

January 2002

LINEAGE

Successor to Matayoshi

FORMER ROLE

Kancho, Matayoshi Kodokan

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The Okinawa Kobudo Doushi Rensei-Kai is an organization of people who pursue maturity of one's personality through learning Okinawa Kobudo.

— OKDR FOUNDING PRINCIPLE

Train in the tradition.

OKDR member dojos teach traditional Okinawan kobudo across multiple continents. Find a dojo near you, or visit the honbu dojo in Waukesha to train directly under Hanshi Stolsmark.

[FIND A MEMBER DOJO](#)